

The SLATE Campus



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THE SLATE

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Week of Welcoming New York Tech's New President Dr. Jerry Balentine

By: Ashley Alexander

Dr. Jerry Balentine – Director of the Emergency Department at St. Barnabas Hospital. Advocate for fitness and mental health amongst medical students. Goat farmer and founder of Woodstock Goat Yoga in the Catskills. And now, the 5th president of New York Institute of Technology!

From the 14th to the 21st of October, our campus hosted our “Week of Welcome,” where we officially welcomed Dr. Balentine with a series of exciting events, with something for everyone to participate in. We kicked off the Week of Welcome with AutumnFest, a beloved annual tradition where students enjoyed festive fall activities and got to hear a few words from Dr. Balentine. Throughout the week, he attended insightful discussion panels hosted by the College of Engineering and Computing Sciences, as well as NYITCOM, where our distinguished speakers and alumni explored and discussed current topics in engineering and medicine. Dr. Balentine cut the ribbon at the opening ceremony of our new NESTS startup center, a launchpad for our student entrepreneurs that offers them the inspiration and mentorship they need to start successful businesses. On October 16, Dr. Balentine was officially inaugurated as the 5th president of New York Institute of Technology. Our students and faculty are thrilled to have Dr. Balentine as our new president. Here is a recap of all the exciting events held to welcome him to our campus!

AutumnFest

As the leaves change color, the days grow shorter, and a crisp breeze fills the air, New York Tech students celebrate the start of the season with the annual AutumnFest! Though this year's AutumnFest had to be held indoors in the SAC gym due to inclement weather, the festive fall spirit was no less! Students got to enjoy activities such as archery, pumpkin painting, and indulging in some delicious fall treats! Dr. Balentine kicked off AutumnFest with a few words of welcome.

He was especially glad to see the petting zoo with goats like his very own! He encouraged students to not only prioritize academics but also take time to have new experiences and grow as a person, whether that means shooting an arrow, petting a goat, or even just relaxing with friends at AutumnFest!



Photo by Ashley Alexander

College of Engineering and Computing Sciences Panel: Women in STEM

Accomplished female industry professionals in STEM gathered at Harry J. Schure Hall to discuss their career journeys, successes, and challenges they faced as women in traditionally male-dominated fields. Panelists and attendees had an insightful discussion on the barriers that women working in the engineering, business, and technology industries continue to face. Our distinguished panelists included software engineer and New

York Tech alum Elizabeth Dwulit, escalation manager at Zebra Technologies, Rhonda Green, CEO of Applied DNA Sciences, Judy Murrah, project manager of the multinational accounting firm Deloitte, Joyce Onore, and president of Mac Fhionnghaile and Sons Electrical Contracting, Andra Voicu. They hope to foster a culture of empowerment and provide encouragement and mentorship to female students at New York Tech, hoping to build a career in these fields.

NYITCOM Community Health event: What's New and Exciting in Cardiovascular Medicine: 2025 Update

As the rate of heart disease continues to rise in the US, it is now more important than ever for medical professionals to research and collaborate to find effective interventions and improve outcomes for patients. At this discussion panel held at NYITCOM, a team of innovative cardiologists led by Dr. Arthur Klein, M.D., explored groundbreaking developments in the detection, prevention, and treatment of cardiovascular disease in people of all ages. Dr. Joseph Puma, D.O., discussed the use of cardiac CT scans to help detect coronary artery disease much earlier than current diagnostic techniques. Dr. Evan Shlofmitz, D.O., informed attendees on the “Cath Lab of the Future,” Aimage blockages in the coronary arteries of the heart. And finally, Dr. Patrick Flynn discussed surgical interventions for infants with congenital heart disease and how to monitor heart health in people of all ages. A fellow osteopathic physician, Dr. Balentine, attended as well to show support for cardiovascular research.



Photo Courtesy of New York Tech

Startup Tech Central Ribbon Cutting

This year, New York Tech is offering an exciting new opportunity for student entrepreneurs of the Innovation and Entrepreneurship Academy to turn their ideas into successful startup businesses. The Startup Tech Central, located in Ed Hall, offers a dedicated space for students to design their prototypes, learn the fundamentals of small business operation, and gain mentorship from innovators in the field. Students at Startup Tech Central take part in the Necessary Eleven Steps to Tech Startup (NESTS) class, a structured course to help get their startups up and running and showcase their ventures at conferences around the state.

Dr. Balentine was given the honor of cutting the ribbon to officially open the Startup Tech Central. He has high hopes that the startup center and all the resources it has to offer will be a launchpad to success for our student entrepreneurs. “We want to make sure that all our students secure jobs, have careers of their dreams, and are successful. Startup Tech Central and the Academy are for those students who want to start something on their own. This is for those students and their creativity.”



Photo Courtesy of New York Tech



Coffee with the President

Many New York Tech students like to start off the day with a nice cup of coffee. Whether you prefer a smooth black coffee or a refreshing iced latte, what better way to get your morning fix of caffeine than with the new president? Dr. Balentine took a ride around campus in the food truck and greeted students heading to their morning classes with a cup of coffee and a big smile.



Photo by Sruti Tadikonda

Inauguration Ceremony

On October 16, Dr. Jerry Balentine was officially inaugurated as the 5th president of New York Institute of Technology. He was presented with the seal of the university by the New York Tech Board of Trustees Chair, Peter J. Romano. Student Representative and President of the Student Government Association, T'ron Strapp, remarked to Balentine, "We ask that you continue to listen to our voices, embrace our ideas, and ensure that New York Tech remains a place where creativity and innovation thrive," said

Strapp. "We look forward to your leadership in building a future where New York Tech continues to transform students into leaders, dreamers into doers, and challenges into opportunities." At the ceremony, Dr. Balentine shared his vision to make New York Tech the "engine that changes students' lives" and prepares them not only to be successful in the workforce but also to become "the next generation of world citizens."



Dr. Jerry Balentine at graduation.

Dr. Jerry Balentine, D.O., has held many titles throughout his career, and we are glad to welcome him as the president of New York Tech! Dr. Balentine has always been deeply committed to improving the education of medical students of NYITCOM, while also prioritizing their mental health and work-life balance. For more than 20 years, he served as faculty in NYITCOM's Department of Clinical Specialties and as Vice President in the Center for Global Health. Dr. Balentine has also conducted research into non-academic interventions to prevent burnout amongst medical students, achieving physical fitness through e-sports, and the prevention of chronic injuries. While not serving as the newest president of New York Tech, you can find Dr. Balentine playing with his dogs or tending to his herd of adorable Nigerian Dwarf Goats in his farm, Woodstock Goat Yoga.

Editors note: From all the students and faculty of New York Institute of Technology, we are excited to have Dr. Jerry Balentine as our new president, and we look forward to many bright years ahead!

Thank You From The Editor

Dear readers of *The Campus Slate*,

I want to extend a sincere thank you to everyone who has added so much to this publication, both in video journalism as well as in writing, editing, and layout, in addition to all of the artistic views and contributions. Thank you to the whole team and you, the New York Tech community!

The ultimate support and revamping of The Slate is thanks to Prof. Horton's help and vision. So, as always, thank you!

Leading and working with this team has been a great collaborative experience for me, and I am always very impressed that despite your busy schedules, you meet the deadlines while maintaining that same quality in your work. Producing each print/online issue takes a lot of coordination and patience. I am grateful for everyone's friendship and the effort shown throughout this semester. All of our new members have adjusted and learned so readily. Our existing members have also continued to manage everything very well and enthusiastically. Thank you!

To the incoming main leadership, Sameer Kumar as the new Editor-in-Chief and Inaya Syed as Managing Editor: I am very confident you will both continue guiding the publication in the most effective, human way. As Managing Editor, Sameer, you have handled everything from cameraman to editor to leadership for so long. In addition, you both have all of the skills, and most importantly, the sincere perspective needed to support all of the workload. I look forward to seeing how *The Campus Slate* develops under your direction. Thank you both! (And shoutout to those who have prioritized attending the meetings, interviewing fellow students, sharing ideas, and definitely keeping up your thoughtful, interesting columns!)

To our readers: thank you again for following our content and engaging with it. Your interest and sup-

port have kept the articles on on-campus events and news relevant, and our writers excited to write more!

As I graduate, I am glad to have gotten to know and learn with everyone, and I know that you will continue to make amazing contributions to our publication.

Beste Tatlican

Editor-in-Chief, The Campus Slate

Thank You Beste for Your Dedication to the Slate

It is with heartfelt gratitude that I pen this letter to Beste upon her graduation from New York Tech.

I first met Beste as a freshman in my FCWR 101 class and immediately identified her as not only a fantastic student but a person with integrity and maturity who got along with everyone.

I'm also the advisor of the Manhattan Globe, the student publication on the Manhattan Campus, and Beste joined the staff there as a writer, where she continued to impress me.

In the summer of 2024, I was asked to also be the advisor of *The Campus Slate* come September. I immediately reached out to Beste (as well as Sameer, our Managing Editor) in hopes they would join the club and help me rejuvenate the publication... it hadn't been printing for nearly a year and was in a sense dormant. To my delight they agreed and despite her hectic schedule as a BSDO major, she jumped into the position of Editor-in-Chief with both feet.

My career at New York Tech started in 2013 in the Communication Arts Department through Video Journalism and I wanted to bring that to the Slate's platform. I remember at one of our first meetings telling the students I'd like to add video to our platform saying to Beste that I'd like her to be the on-air reporter. As I

handed her a microphone I said, “There is an event going on right now we can report on.” Without hesitation Beste did the first video journalism piece for the Slate setting the tone for a fantastic new YouTube channel. (“Banned Book Giveaway | EIC Beste Tatlican interviews the organizers on the spot!”)

I will be forever grateful to Beste for taking on the challenge of being Editor-in-Chief of the Slate. She truly made an impact on the Slate’s legacy. As she moves on to new beginnings and medical school, I know she will continue to make a positive impact on the world.

Prof. K. Horton

Faculty Advisor, The Campus Slate

Thank You Beste... I’ll Take It From Here.

I met someone special at New York Tech’s May 2024 Commencement Ceremony, Beste Tatlican. She and I were both a part of The Manhattan Globe (the student-based newspaper on the Manhattan campus), as staff writers. As we introduced ourselves and got to know each other that day while distributing the Globe-Slate commencement edition, something truly stood out and inspired me: her passion for journalism, and her dream to be a doctor in the future. Just our conversation that day alone reminded me of how dedicated and focused one should be in their academic career. Beste inspired me to keep going regardless of all the doubts and fears I might have had thinking about my second year and beyond.

In the summer ahead and months after, I constantly thought about our conversation when we met for the first time and kept Beste’s words in mind as my driving force. I really wanted to see Beste take on a leadership position. I was thinking to myself, “she should be more than a staff writer... she is a true leader.” She had the experience, was capable, carried herself professionally, and most importantly, was perfect at collaborating/socializing with others—(a skill that many people didn’t utilize as much since the pandemic, including myself).

Just a month and a half after volunteering at

the commencement ceremony, I received a text message from Professor Horton on July 20th saying that he was recently appointed as the advisor of *The Campus Slate*, and he wanted me to join the new team of students. I was extremely excited, not only because it would keep me busy during downtime when I’m not in class or studying, but also because I felt that I had found an additional space where I could bring my hobbies and passions to reality. Finding out that I would be working alongside one of my favorite professors I’ve had since day 1 of my college career, and a group of students I would meet, made me so happy. I had joined the Globe team just a few months back, and now I was given another huge opportunity to help out another publication. I couldn’t be more grateful. Just at the same time as Prof Horton asked me, I was thinking about other students who could be a huge asset as the publication sets upon a new stage. Immediately, Beste came to mind, and I hoped she would join.

During our first meeting in the Fall 2024 semester, Professor Horton discussed with the staff his vision of bringing back The Slate to life after it had been dormant. We needed someone to fill the position of editor-in-chief. I’m so glad and thankful that Beste confidently stepped in.

During her time on The Slate, Beste played multiple roles within that one position, excelled at every single one, took on new challenges, and played a crucial role in transforming the image of our student publication. When we first joined, it wasn’t about continuing what the Slate was already giving to the New York Tech community, but to bring back its presence on a campus where students and faculty might have forgotten about it. This is mostly due to an extended time period when print editions were not being released, new content wasn’t being published, the social media handles were inactive, etc. Bringing the publication back to life meant consistency and responsibility for us as a team. Beste led the team wholeheartedly and encouraged each and every staff member to work together, creating bonds and a sense of collaboration in the rejuvenation process.

She planned every meeting, keeping and always thinking one step ahead. She always said to the staff that if everyone wanted to see all their hard work come together in time, having proper deadlines and keeping

up with them was very important. She always reminded the staff that the community around us is awaiting the next edition, video, or social media post just as much as we are looking forward to seeing our efforts come to reality. Beste set the goal to have print issues with a variety of topics, a puzzle/entertainment section at the back, and release on a consistent schedule.

Beste has been constantly there for each member of the team from the very initial steps of brainstorming ideas to ensuring everyone's work was published, whether it would be in print or digitally. Over the past year and a half of working with her, Beste has set the true example of having the right attitude even in times of unexpected challenges. There were moments when the deadline to submit the file to the printer was so near, and we were still editing articles that were being submitted at the last minute. Rather than becoming anxious about anything or having doubts about whether things could stay on schedule, Beste kept making progress in a relaxed yet determined state of mind, knowing that everything would get done as planned in the end. That had motivated me immensely.

In that first semester, we added something new to the Slate's journalism platform, and it was something I knew Beste would handle amazingly well, but it turned out even better than that. The Slate was always known for covering campus life and all the different events that occurred throughout the school year at New York Tech in the form of printed articles. In the current age of social media, video reels and shorts, and digital storytelling, Beste not only did a wonderful job being on camera by giving online Slate followers an exclu-

sive look at the events. She covered events such as the NYIT Library and Humanities Department's Banned Book Giveaway and Student Life's Grizzly Games, but also encouraged her team to come out of their comfort zone and try filming and/or interviewing.

Reflecting back on the past year and a half, I am incredibly grateful for what Beste has given to the Slate, to our staff, and to me. The impact was tremendous in ways that go above and beyond the student magazine... I've seen growth in myself because of her. The past 18 months have been filled with nothing but an inspirational and learning experience for me through so many memories made from meeting discussions to late-night editing. Watching her perform all duties as EIC in such a calm and smooth manner, as well as working with her on our platform, helped me gain insight into what goes into a leadership position.

Time has flown by, and today it is hard to believe that I am already writing this letter of gratitude to Beste as she graduates from New York Tech. All that she has done has set a new foundation for The Slate, something that will stay forever. I'm so honored that Beste has appointed me to follow in her footsteps as the New EIC starting next semester, starting January 2026. I know that every issue published going forward, every decision made, and all the work our publication will continue to produce will be shaped by all that Beste has done.

Thank you, Beste, I'll take it from here.

Sameer Kumar

Managing Editor, The Campus Slate



Staff photo, From left to right, Inaya Syed, Ashley Alexander, Beste Tatlican, Sameer Kumar, Daniel Galvin Gusmano, Mia Mancina, and Prof. K. Horton as Batman- it was Halloween :-)

Student Finances: A Guide

By: Inaya Syed

Three years ago, when I first started my college career at New York Tech, I did not know much about finances. I was a desperate, starving student. I didn't know how to build credit or how to finance anything. When I received my first paycheck ever, I spent most of it on the bills I had to pay.

Many students like me have recently been struggling with the concept of saving money. Here are ten tips so you can start early.

1. Quit the “Pay-in-Four” Apps

Personally, I struggled with this problem quite a lot! “Pay-in-Four” apps, otherwise known as “buy now, pay later”, are a major contributor to debt in Generation Z. According to the Consumer Financial Bureau, “buy now, pay later” users have borrowed an average of \$2,085.00 per year. I would use “buy now, pay later” apps whenever I wanted to purchase something out of my budget. However, I wouldn't recommend doing this!

2. Stop buying from fast-fashion websites

Fast-fashion websites such as Shein, Temu, etc. contribute to global warming. Even worse, it is not of great quality. You can buy better products at Walmart, Amazon, or Target! For example, if you break your pencil sharpener, you can easily either purchase a new one in-store (which is cheaper if available) or on the website of e-commerce companies like Amazon. According to Sustainability Magazine, Shein used to sell small products that were similar and/or cuter, but ever since their shift to clothing, they have racked up 23.1% of global impact on the environment. Overall, if you want something affordable and “cute”, I would highly encourage checking out other companies that offer better quality products.

3. Utilize student resources (student discounts, student programs)

Utilize most student resources available to you at New York Tech! When I was a freshman, I used Adobe Suite, a platform to use Adobe products for a subscription price. Did I use the student discount? No, I didn't. But it would have saved me so much money rather than just paying a basic, plain subscription. New York Tech offers a lot of discounts. Also, check resources such as StudentBeans.com, myunidays.com, totum.com, or any other websites that offer student discount programs. Amazon Prime, which is \$8.14 per month, and Spotify, priced at \$5.99 per month, offer student discounts. Most companies do have student perks, so be on the lookout!

4. Utilize On-Campus Resources (Campus shuttle, NICE Bus Passes)

On-campus resources can also help minimize costs. For those who do not know, the university has an on-campus shuttle from the Hicksville, Long Island, Railroad directly to campus. It is completely free. There is a schedule on either the website or the bus stop on campus. For those who take the Nassau Inter-County Express(NICE) buses, there is the option of ten to twenty bus passes. Why ten to twenty? This is because each individual MetroCard is preloaded with \$5.50. The usual fare for these buses is \$2.90 per trip taken on the bus. This information can also be found on the New York Tech website.

5. When starting a business/venture, map out your necessary costs!

This is essential for new startup founders! You need to map out your necessary costs! Either start a Google Sheet to track expenses, or use a finance tracker like NerdWallet to record and organize your expenses! For example, in my startup, Sound-Damp, I used a ton

of my own money to finance my startup and develop prototypes, without recording the expenses anywhere for supplies and patents. Speaking of patent finances, pay them as soon as possible. The regular, undiscounted non-provisional patent cost is \$300.00. However, if you do manage to get micro-entity status (which is eligible for student-run patents), it is only seventy dollars. Make sure everything is finished. Otherwise, you will have to pay more in the future.

6. Pay a set amount of money for your loans (if applicable)

One of the best decisions I made when starting at New York Tech was to pay a set amount of money per month on my student loans. It is something I learned from my older siblings to set aside some money for loans. This way, you have a low principal amount. What is the principal amount on a loan? It is the amount of money you owe before interest is applied. When choosing a loan, go for Subsidized options. This means that throughout your time at New York Tech, your loan accreditors cannot charge interest on your loans while you're studying your major. It is a great option; however, it is applicable if you can spare that expense. I know tuition can be expensive, so I also arranged to pay a good portion of the tuition I owe with my parents. This is also due to the financial support of my job through the Federal Work-Study program.

7. Use a low-balance credit card with 0% interest

This is something I feel like a lot of people struggle with. What do I mean by "low-balance?" I mean, deposit only 5% of your paychecks on the credit card(s) you use. Also, try to only use one credit card. The more credit cards you obtain, the more credit card debt you could pile up on yourself. You should also use a low-fee credit card, such as a 0% interest card. I recommend Kikoff, which is a platform to help build your credit while keeping costs low. It is only five to ten dollars per month, depending on your payment plan. Credit is useful when trying to buy a car, a house, or a large investment, like a start-up. However, be responsible about it. Pay each month!

8. Do not buy unnecessary single-use "trendy" items (boo-baskets, labubus, etc.)

I think this is very obvious, yet so many adults struggle with it! Do not buy unnecessary items like labubus, boo-baskets, and social media trends! I have seen so many social media ads that insist that you "have to buy this" or "it is going to change your life!" Do not buy into the overconsumption trends.

9. Buy when you run out/break something

This is something that often affects all students. Similar to the last point of not buying into the overconsumption of products, buy only when you break something irreparable, or when you run out. We are students, and we cannot afford the overconsumption of life—whether it be technology, bath products, or anything else. As someone who was a former shopaholic, this is not sustainable in the long run.

10. Do not choose delivery (unless you have to) on anything

Now, I am going to emphasize one of the most important points: delivery. I am aware that most students find it convenient to deliver to the school. While I am aware clubs do that under the supervision of the Student Government Association, individual orders do not apply to that! Unless you absolutely have to, don't spend extra fees on delivery. If you do delivery, look for the website of the place you want to order from and check if the place can actually deliver to the campus and they have either an order minimum or they offer no delivery fees at all.

I hope this helps you in your financial journey!

The First Generation Student Experience

By: Mia Mancia

Introduction

In this season of reflecting on what we are grateful for, I am especially thankful for going to college at New York Institute of Technology. I am a first-generation college student, and I wanted to highlight some things about it. Going to college as a first-gen student can feel like running through an obstacle course. From writing college essays and the application process, to the first day of classes, preparing for exams, and creating personal connections, these are all valuable experiences. I am currently in my second year at New York Tech, and I am proud to be a first-generation college student. A first-generation college student means you are the first person in your family to go to college. According to the university's website, 30% of undergraduate students are first-generation.

Struggles

The student fills out college applications and applies for financial aid without parental guidance. The student fills it all out on their own or seeks guidance from school counselors or teachers. There might be a sense of pressure from the family because they ask how it is going with the process, and sometimes we are struggling, but we say it's going well because we don't want to worry them. I've learned that it is okay to admit that we struggle, but also to seek help. Balancing school work, a job, and family responsibilities can be challenging. Some students take care of loved ones, provide transportation, prepare meals, pay bills, and school tuition, as well as support family expenses. It is also very important to take time to care for mental health. Many students go through imposter syndrome, which is a feeling of not belonging or feeling not smart enough.

Strengths

First-generation students are great examples of resilience and determination. You are looked up to by younger siblings, younger relatives, and friends. Having someone in the family who goes to college is an accomplishment, and it adds to cultural and family pride. Many first-gen students have a positive attitude towards college with excitement and gratitude. We even inspire ourselves.

First Gen Voices

• Anonymous Sophomore Student

- Q: What motivates you?
- A: "My parents did not go to high school or college, so I'm the first person to do it. That is a privilege. The reason why they weren't able to go to school is that they had to work and provide for their family."
- Q: What challenges do you face?
- A: "The cost of tuition is a lot. Thankfully, the school offers payment plans. I commute and drive 2 hours every day. The best option right now is to commute. There is also the gas costs."
- Q: What does being first-gen mean to you?
- A: "It makes me feel proud."

• Anonymous Freshman Student

- Q: How is your first year experience going?
- A: "My first year experience has been difficult and is something new; however, it's good knowing everyone else is going through the same thing. Adjusting is the hardest part, but finding your routine and what's best is important."
- Q: What motivates you to pursue a college degree?

- A: “My career. I’m passionate about my career, and even if it’s hard right now, I know it will be worth it in the end.”
- Q: Who has helped you to navigate college life?
- A: “I would say upperclassmen and professors. Taking their advice and tips has been the most helpful guide to understanding how I can do my best in classes and make the most of social life.”

My experience

Being first-generation to me means I get to create history in my family. On the first day of college, I felt like a new version of myself. It was the start of a new chapter in my life, where I would meet new people in a new setting and develop my potential. My family always encouraged me to do well in school and believed that I would go to college. Neither of my parents has a college degree, but they still knew I was capable of taking such a step in life. In my family, we view college as a bridge to a good career and success.

I had the opportunity to receive guidance from my high school counselors. They helped me and my peers in our graduating class in applying to colleges, scholarships, and financial aid. I remember overthinking about picking a major, how to write my personal statement, and how to apply for financial aid, but my college counselors supported me through it all.

During the first few weeks of my first semester in college ever, I was quite lost. Many people seemed to know what they were doing, while I didn’t know the terms “undergraduate” and “graduate”, what office hours were, or that tutoring was free at NYIT. At times, I experience imposter syndrome and self-doubt. But I don’t let it all prevent me from giving my best. Last year, I thought I would fail my calculus course, but I locked in and passed with good grades. Moments like these are invaluable.

Being a first-generation student has helped me discover a new self. This journey has allowed me to become more confident and independent. While my parents didn’t have the opportunity to experience college life themselves, they are constantly cheering me on every step of the way. I am part of approximately 8.2 million first-gen undergraduate college students across the US, and I have to say—I am proud of us. I believe that every student at our school should be grateful for going to college at New York Tech and value every experience.

Resources & Support

- Programs, clubs, counselors, advisors, professors.
- Peer Success Guide Program, which matches first-year students with 2nd, 3rd, or 4th year students for peer guidance.
- First Generation Club
- PATH program for 2nd and 3rd year students.
- National or regional organizations and scholarships for first-generation students

A program at NYIT that helped me a lot, particularly, is the Peer Success Guide program. My PSG was very helpful—shout out to Bianca Ajodhia and all PSGs!



58th Annual MACUB Conference

By: Daniel Galvin Gusmano

The frontiers of research in biology returned with the hundreds of students and professors who arrived at Molloy University for the Metropolitan Association of College and University Biologists (MACUB) Conference on October 25th, 2025. The MACUB Conference is an opportunity for students to present their biological research in the various subjects, including Biochemistry, Biophysics and Biotechnology, Clinical, Developmental Biology and Genetics, Environmental Biology and Ecology, Microbiology and Immunology, as well as Physiology and Neuroscience. Students from New York Institute of Technology participated by presenting their research with mentors. Dr. William Letsou, Dr. Bryan Gibb, and Dr. Jacqueline Keighron from the Biological and Chemical Sciences Department attended the MACUB conference as mentors and judges. It was a great opportunity to present and share ideas in a forum of students and professors with various biology backgrounds.

The format of this conference was similar to last year's, but the speakers emphasized the importance of bioindicators to help preserve the environment. The keynote speaker, Dr. Jessica Ware, who is the Curator and Division Chair of Invertebrate Zoology at the American Museum of Natural History, presented her research on "Dragonflies and Damselflies as Climate Biomonitorers." Her research mainly focused on studying the behavior of various species of dragonflies and damselflies to gather information about the environment based on how well these organisms were surviving.

These organisms require specific environmental conditions to survive and reproduce, making them excellent biomarkers. Migration patterns of dragonflies were identified, and the expansion of urban-adapted species was investigated. While populations of some species are now dwindling due to the climate change factor and the increased land development of human cities, other species start to expand due to their adap-

tations, allowing them to survive within a human-influenced environment. The importance of the environment was emphasized, especially the need to protect these species that are now approaching extinction as a result of pollutants created by humans.



*Photo courtesy of
MACUB Conference 2025*

After Dr. Jessica Ware's presentation, the students had an opportunity to present their research. Various sections of posters were set up that morning for each subject. Once students presented their work to three judges, they were allowed to visit others' presentations and learn about the various topics available. Poster presentations were available to anyone who was interested in the topic in which the research was completed.

Later on, presentations by the current faculty took place. There was also a discussion board for the students regarding the different paths within research, with many achieving a PhD in their respective research areas. It was an informative discussion where the students had an opportunity to ask various questions and expand their knowledge.

The event concluded with a presentation by Dr. Kristy L. Biolsi, who is an Associate Professor of Psychology at Marist University. The presentation was on "Pinnipeds as Sentinels of the Sea." Her research focused on the impact of domoic acid, which can be produced in large quantities by algal blooms, on the environment. She studied its effects on organisms that were exposed to this chemical. Domoic acid acts as a strong neurotoxicine which can affect marine life and humans. An experiment was set up where a seal would need to remember which path to take in order to get a fish reward. This was completed with seals that were both exposed and not exposed to domoic acid. The seals that were exposed to domoic acid could not remember the correct path for the fish reward. This was noted as an issue since these memory deficiencies also indicate that seals would have difficulty remembering their hunting grounds, making it challenging for them to obtain fish for vital nutrients. The presentation highlighted the environmental impact these large algal blooms are creating and the importance of people proceeding in a direction that will improve this situation, since algae blooms are only increasing as a result of climate change.

Awards were announced for the various sections of subjects that the students presented. Many students from NYIT received an award for their presentation. Attia Andrew, Patel Yamini, Sinha Ashika, Ravani Vishva, and Bhuvha Heer received second place in the Biochemistry, as well as the Biophysics and Biotechnology Category for their research on "Shape and Textural

Nuclear Features in Multiclassification of Dysplastic Pre-cancerous Cells Towards the Screening of Cervical Cancer." John Youssef, Gregory Lipkovich, Raquel Mulakandov, Abdur-Rehman Hussain, Muntaha Ahmad, and Jacqueline D. Keighron received third place in the Biochemistry, Biophysics and Biotechnology categories for their research on "Nanoscale Curvature Modulates Glucose Oxidase Structure and Catalytic Function." Stanley Pierre Louis, Sumreet Baidwan, and Aminah Sarowar received second place in the Microbiology and Immunology Category for their research on "Pseudolysogenic Behavior of Arthrobacter Phage Swim."

To get involved in research, reach out to your professors for opportunities. In addition, more information about this year's MACUB Conference can be found on their website: <https://www.macub.info/>. The university in which this conference takes place changes every year, so stay updated for more information about next year's event!



*Photo credits: courtesy of
MACUB Conference 2025*

What's New in Cardiology?

The 2025 Update

By: Ashley Alexander

NYITCOM presents the latest updates in cardiovascular medicine in a fascinating discussion panel. Learn about how cardiologists are using innovative imaging techniques and minimally invasive catheterization procedures to help improve the lives of patients of all ages with heart conditions!

For nearly a century, heart disease rates have been steadily climbing throughout the world. Statistics from the American Heart Association (AHA) show that approximately every 40 seconds, one person dies due to a heart attack. Nearly 20 million people around the world have been diagnosed with some form of cardiovascular disease, which can include heart attacks, coronary artery disease, and strokes, among others. Heart disease is not only a common problem, but also an expensive one too: the AHA also reports that 129.3 billion dollars are spent annually to treat it. The massive prevalence of these conditions raises an important question for the medical field: How can we fight the battle against heart disease and decrease its global prevalence? And for those who are affected, how can we increase the accuracy of diagnosis, stage more effective interventions, and help them live longer, more fulfilling lives?

At NYIT College of Osteopathic Medicine (NYITCOM), cardiovascular physicians and researchers gathered at the de Seversky Mansion to find the answers to these questions in the insightful discussion panel “What’s New and Exciting in Cardiovascular Medicine: 2025 update”. Dr. Arthur Klein, M.D., led the panel, which aimed to educate the public on the latest advancements in the prevention and treatment of heart disease. Dr. Klein served as the president of Mount Sinai Health Network and as a faculty member of NYITCOM, as well as at Columbia University’s Mailman School of Public Health. The panellists, regional leaders in the field of cardiovascular research, delivered engaging presentations that challenged cur-

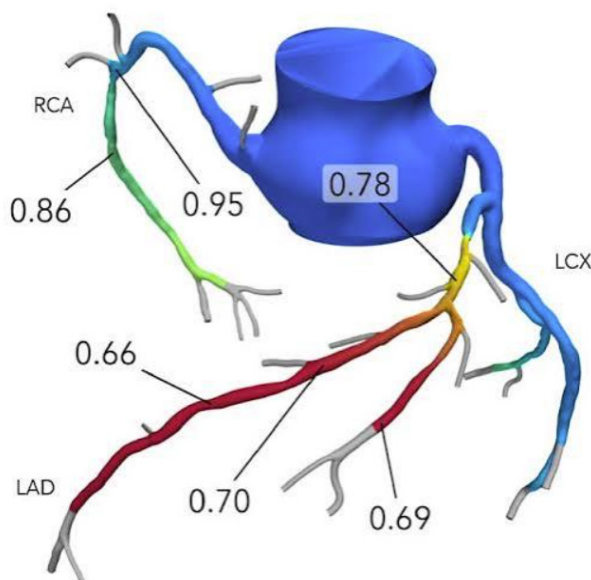
rent ineffective treatment protocols and introduced a variety of innovative new procedures that will transform the way physicians approach heart disease. The discussion panel was followed by an engaging question and answer session before the night came to a close.



From left to right, Dr. Arthur Klein M.D., Dr. Evan Shlofmitz D.O., Dr. Joseph Puma D.O., Dr. Patrick Flynn M.D., Dr. Jerry Balentine D.O., and Dr. Atul Kukar D.O.

The first panellist of the evening was Dr. Evan Shlofmitz, D.O., who is an interventional cardiologist at St. Francis Hospital. As the Director of Intravascular Imaging at Dr. Shlofmitz leads the St. Francis health-care team in guiding catheters, which are thin, flexible tubes with tiny cameras, into blood vessels to visualize the inside of the heart and blood vessels. Cardiac catheterization is often used to treat Coronary Artery Disease (CAD), where the coronary arteries that feed the heart with oxygen become blocked with plaque. By using the catheter to clear blockages and insert stents, which keep the arteries open, the heart’s blood supply is preserved, and the patient’s risk of a heart attack is reduced! At this discussion panel, Dr. Shlofmitz introduced the “Cath Lab of the Future,” which integrates CT scanning, cardiac catheterization, as well as AI analysis to not only visualize dangerous coronary artery blockages, but also determine their risk in causing a heart attack. One such procedure used in the “Cath

Lab of the Future” is Fractional Flow Reserve derived from Computer Tomography (FFRCT). In this minimally invasive analytical technique, the catheter is first placed in the affected coronary arteries, and a CT scan creates a 3D model of the blockage, recording its shape and size. Using this image, AI-assisted computer programs can now use advanced fluid dynamic modeling to calculate pressure and blood flow in the arteries. In the past, cardiologists could only rely on the image of the blockage; they had to estimate its effect on blood flow and use invasive procedures to clear it away. With FFRCT, cardiologists get a much more comprehensive understanding of the blockage’s form as well as its impact on function. They can easily and quickly identify which coronary arteries are at risk for becoming completely blocked and causing a heart attack. Analysis provided by the FFRCT can help the provider determine whether the patient would best benefit from medication, stenting, or bypass surgery, thus minimizing the need for unnecessary invasive procedures.



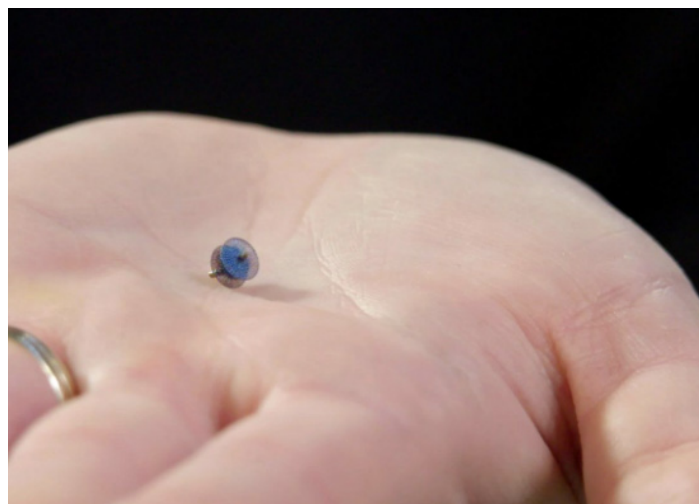
A Fractional Flow Reserve derived from Computer Tomography (FFRCT) reading, showing the structure of the coronary arteries and velocity of blood flow in them.

Image Credits: www.heartflow.com

The second panellist of the evening was Dr. Joseph Puma D.O., founder and president of Sorin Medical, a cardiovascular care center based in New York City. Dr. Puma is an advocate for Coronary CT Angiography as a first-line diagnostic assessment for Coronary Artery Disease. Coronary Artery Disease is a “silent killer”, as it often develops in patients above the age of 40 without obvious symptoms. Left untreated, it can lead to heart attacks, Congestive Heart Failure (CHF), and many other disastrous consequences. At present, a third of patients who have a heart attack find out for the first time that they have Coronary Artery Disease. It shouldn’t take a heart attack for patients to finally figure out that something is wrong with their heart! Based on this statistic, Dr. Puma asserted the need for a more accurate and affordable diagnostic test to detect Coronary Artery Disease in its early stages, so patients can be treated before they face irreparable damage to their hearts. Currently, the stress test is the primary procedure to analyze heart function in patients suspected of having CAD. This test requires the patient to exercise on a stationary bike for a brief period of time while a blood pressure cuff and EKG electrodes on their chest measure the activity of the heart under stress. Stress testing and other current diagnostic measures that assess cardiovascular function give an incomplete picture of the patient’s heart health: they fail to identify the specific areas where the coronary arteries are narrowing and the blood supply is being limited. They are not only unreliable, but also cost a lot of money! In the past year, more than 80 billion dollars were spent on the diagnosis and treatment of ischemic heart disease, an expense that can be relieved with early, accurate diagnosis and intervention. Dr. Puma’s answer to this pressing issue is the Coronary CT Angiogram (CCTA). The CCTA is a quick, noninvasive scan of the heart that provides a detailed picture of all the coronary arteries and an in-depth analysis of blood flow in all areas of the heart. In just 4 minutes, the cardiologist and patient will be well-informed on the patient’s risk status for a heart attack, and intervene before it gets worse. In addition, the CCTA procedure is half the cost of the stress test! With this early, accurate, and affordable diagnostic test, patients can be more proactive about their cardiovascular health and prevent heart attacks before they even happen!

The last panellist of the evening was Dr. Patrick Flynn, M.D., a pediatric cardiologist at New York Presbyterian/Weill Cornell Medical Center. Dr. Flynn explored the tremendous progress made in the treatment of congenital heart disease, one of the most common birth defects. In the past, parents of a baby born with heart disease could do little but accept the fact that their baby would not be able to make it to childhood. Due to the recent innovations in surgical and non-surgical interventions, as well as advanced neonatal cardiac monitoring, more of these babies are growing up to be healthy and thriving adults! One of the most prevalent forms of congenital heart disease is Patent Ductus Arteriosus (PDA). In the mother's uterus, the baby has a temporary artery called the ductus arteriosus that allows the blood to bypass their not-yet-functional lungs. When the baby is born and starts to breathe air, the ductus arteriosus is meant to close so circulation of oxygen-poor and oxygen-rich blood can be separated. In 1 in 2000 babies, the ductus arteriosus fails to close properly, which causes oxygen-poor blood to mix with oxygen-rich blood. Left untreated, this can lead to excess workload on the heart and high pressure in the lungs.

To treat this condition, Dr. Flynn introduced the Piccolo Occluder, a device used to close the ductus arteriosus and restore normal function of the heart. Insertion of the Piccolo Occluder is a minimally invasive procedure, done with a tiny catheter about the width of a hair. The catheter carrying the device is inserted into the baby's groin and guided to the heart, where the Piccolo Occluder is released and firmly plugs the opening of the Ductus Arteriosus. The small size of the Occluder, combined with the minimally invasive nature of the insertion procedure, makes it a viable procedure for affected premature infants weighing as little as 1.5 pounds! A study following PDA patients who received a Piccolo Occluder found 100% closure of the Ductus Arteriosus after 3 years, and a 95% survival rate overall. With devices such as the Piccolo Occluder, babies with congenital heart diseases can avoid risky open-heart surgeries and go on to live happy, active lives.



A tiny Piccolo Occluder device is used to close the Patent Ductus Arteriosus (PDA) in infants with congenital heart disease.

Image Credits: abcnews.go.com

The discussion panel closed with a question to all attendees: How can we work alongside medical researchers to promote cardiovascular health and improve health outcomes for patients of all backgrounds? The field of medical research will never stop evolving. New discoveries emerge every year to produce even higher-resolution images of the heart and develop new procedures to combat cardiovascular disease and restore healthy function. Eliminating heart disease will not occur through research alone. It will only come about through a collaboration between researchers, legislators, healthcare providers, educators, and most importantly, you! By raising awareness of the prevalence of cardiovascular disease and modeling lifestyle changes to maintain heart health, you can help protect yourself and your community from developing heart disease.



President Spotlight Word Hunt

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